thought of as a somewhat eccentric endeavor. Something that could occupy the time of formerly productive physicists once they reached a certain age and were ready to abandon real work.

In 1933, Einstein left Germany and took a position at the new Institute for Advanced Study in Princeton, New Jersey, where he would remain until his death in 1955. His technical work after 1935 focused largely on classical general relativity and his search for a unified theory of gravitation and electromagnetism, but he never stopped thinking about quantum mechanics. Bohr would occasionally visit Princeton, where he and Einstein would carry on their dialogue.

John Archibald Wheeler joined the physics faculty at Princeton University, down the road from the Institute and Einstein, as an assistant professor in 1934. In later years Wheeler would become known as one of the world's experts in general relativity, popularizing the terms "black hole" and "wormhole," but in his early career he concentrated on quantum problems. He had briefly studied under Bohr in Copenhagen, and in 1939 he and Bohr published a pioneering paper on nuclear fission. Wheeler had great admiration for Einstein, but he venerated Bohr; as he would later put it, "Nothing has done more to convince me that there once existed friends of mankind with the human wisdom of Confucius and Buddha, Jesus and Pericles, Erasmus and Lincoln, than walks and talks under the beech trees of Klampenborg Forest with Niels Bohr."

Wheeler made an impact on physics in a number of ways, one of which was in the mentoring of talented graduate students, including future Nobel laureates such as Richard Feynman and Kip Thorne. One of those students was Hugh Everett III, who would introduce a dramatically new approach to thinking about the foundations of quantum mechanics. We've already sketched his basic idea—the wave function represents reality, it evolves smoothly, and that evolution leads to multiple distinct worlds when a quantum measurement takes place—but now we have the tools to do it right.

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Everett's proposal, which eventually became his 1957 PhD thesis at Princeton, can be thought of as the purest incarnation of one of Wheeler's